vCenter VM Snapshots Beginner Practical Guide

VM snapshots act like a save point in a video game before a tough boss fight. Mastering snapshot creation, reversal, and cleanup keeps your virtual infrastructure fast and safe from unexpected crashes.

What you'll learn:

1. Creating a Clean VM Snapshot
2. Rolling Back VM to Safety
3. Merging and Deleting Snapshots
4. Finding Forgotten Old Snapshots

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Creating a Clean VM Snapshot

Creating a snapshot captures the virtual machine disk state at a specific moment before you make risky system edits. Setting Memory to false skips saving the active RAM, which makes snapshot creation much faster and saves valuable datastore space. Always give your snapshot a clear descriptive name so team members know who created it.

```
New-VMSnapshot -VM "WebServer01" -Name "Pre-Upgrade-v2" -Description "Taken before Nginx update" -Me
```

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Rolling Back VM to Safety

When an update corrupts the OS or crashes your app, rolling back restores the VM state instantly to the snapshot point. This action discards all disk changes made after the snapshot was generated. Make sure to coordinate with your team before reverting shared staging servers to avoid overwriting teammate changes.

```
Set-VM -VM "WebServer01" -Snapshot "Pre-Upgrade-v2" -Confirm:$false
```

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Merging and Deleting Snapshots

Deleting a snapshot does not erase your current work; it merges all temporary delta disk changes into the base virtual disk. Leaving snapshots active for weeks causes delta files to grow huge, slowing down VM read/write speeds and consuming extra storage. Clean them up as soon as your tests pass.

```
$Get-VM "WebServer01" | Get-VMSnapshot -Name "Pre-Upgrade-v2" | Remove-VMSnapshot -Confirm:$false
```

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Finding Forgotten Old Snapshots

Forgotten snapshots are the leading cause of unexpected datastore outages in VMware environments. You can run PowerCLI scripts to search across all VMs and surface snapshots created days or weeks ago. Filter results by creation date to find and remove old safety nets before disk space runs out.

```
$Get-VM | Get-VMSnapshot | Where-Object { $_.Created -lt (Get-Date).AddDays(-3) } | Select-Object VM,
```

See Key Takeaways on next page >> linkedin.com/in/mramanrajsingh

Key Takeaways

+ Delete snapshots within 24 to 48 hours after creation.
+ Never use snapshots as a replacement for real system backups.
+ Skip memory state unless saving active RAM processes is required.
+ Consolidate VM disks promptly if vCenter triggers a warning.
+ Check available datastore storage before snapshotting large VMs.

Watch Out For

! Leaving snapshots running for weeks until datastores fill up completely.
! Taking memory snapshots on heavy database VMs, causing freeze times.
! Thinking deleting a snapshot erases recent changes instead of merging them.

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